
On Deep Ecologist's Self-Realization

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Introduction

There are certain basic questions of and for the human species, such as "who we are, what we are heading for, and of what kind of reality we are part"¹. These questions are first and foremost due to the fact that we can and do ask them. They are also due to our presence on the surface of Earth. In relation to these questions and their roots, if one acknowledges that there is an environmental crisis that needs to be solved, a solution should be delivered also. Further, the solution we are looking for is an environmental ethic since the scientific inquiry falls short of providing any motivation for change for better: it only declares hard facts, whenever it can:

Chemistry, physics, and the science of ecology acknowledge only change, not valued change. [...] The inability of the science of ecology to denounce such processes as the washing away of the soil of rain-forests suggests that we need another approach which involves the inescapable role of announcing values, not only 'facts'.²

"All the sciences are fragmentary and incomplete in relation to basic rules and norms, so it's very shallow to think that science can solve our problems. Without basic norms, there is no science. [...]"³

Nor is the answer a political or an economic one, as these fail to provide long term solutions: something deeper than a cost/benefit analysis is required:

Mainstream politicians and other people have acknowledged that there are problems, but they typically believe that mild reforms and improved technology will solve them. Economic growth and increased consumption are still considered central values of the society and so the status quo economy is placed before the environment.⁴

[...] what is needed to solve the eco-crisis "is a transformation of consciousness"⁵

Hence we arrive at the necessity of an environmental ethic that does not shy away from asking deep questions, and trying to answer them. is to be established. One such particular school of thought (and action) that takes this issue one of its primary concerns is deep ecology, first compiled together by Arne Næss. Deep ecology claims that the basic questions cited above—as well as their two roots—are actually fundamentally related. Traditionally the concept of "self" is considered to be pertaining to the former reason, while the latter is related to the connection between man and nature. In this regard Næss claims that the solution lies in a process of extending of the self so that it accommodates man's relation to nature. Næss calls such a process of extending **self-realization**⁶, and the all-inclusive end that is to be reached through

¹[Næ87, p. 35]

²[Næ93, p. 24]

³[DevSes01, p. 75]

⁴[DreDevSch11, p. 102]

⁵[DreDevSch11, p. 103]

⁶**Boldface** denotes the term that is being defined.

self-realization **SELF**⁷. Since self-realization starts with the individual self, it is not a surprise that Næss conceives deep ecology to be practiced through personal philosophies. A projection of deep ecology onto a personal philosophy so that the self (the self in Self and the self of the person) are preserved is an **ecosophy** □, where □ denotes the conservation of the self and is replaced by a specific symbol of choice.

Observe that here the stability of the concept Self requires an understanding of what the connection between man and Nature is. In this paper I will focus on how the connection between man and Nature relates to self-realization according to deep-ecologist. To be fair, the concepts of self-realization and the distinction of self/SELF are components of Næss' personal ecosophy, namely **ecosophy T**⁸ or "**the ecology of self-SELF**"⁹, and so I mean Næss himself whenever I talk of the deep ecologist, though I won't strictly refrain from citing other deep ecologists' ecosophies. This is analogous to the place of Socrates in Plato's writings: there is Socrates the man (presumably) and Socrates the character (or the puppet): they are related but not identical. In this regard the self-realization I will concentrate on is quite possibly a component of some ecosophy T', instead of ecosophy T.

An Outline of Self-Realization

According to Næss there are six points constituent of the notion of self-realization¹⁰:

I (Narrow Ego < SELF) SELF is not reducible to the narrow ego or the self in the individualistic sense. SELF is identical to the Chinese Tao¹¹, or to Gandhi's atman, which corresponds to "the supreme or universal self"¹².

II (Allsided Maturity $\Rightarrow$ Identification) Allsided maturity, that is, maturity "in all major directions", necessitates a process of identification with all living beings. Here living beings include humans, and sentient and nonsentient nonhumans alike, as well as certain things that "biologists classify as "nonliving"; rivers (watersheds), landscapes, ecosystems"¹³.

III (Narrow Ego < Ecological Self < SELF) Traditionally the development of the maturity of the self is conceived as follows: By default a human has a narrow ego. If someone were to ask him "Who are you?", his **narrow ego** would allow him to say "I am not you.", or better yet, "Who are *you*?"¹⁴. Through identification with friends and family the narrow ego

⁷Originally Næss uses "Self" instead of "SELF". This is purely a typographical preference on my part.

⁸[Næ93, p. 4]

⁹[DreDevSch11, p. 108]

¹⁰[Næ87]

¹¹[DevSes01, p. 76]

¹²[Næ87, p. 39]

¹³[NæSes84] This is a precisising of the first basic principle of deep ecology.

¹⁴*Emphasis* emphasizes.

develops into a social ego, which in turn then develops into a metaphysical self by the identification with humanity. These two consecutive developments are called **spiritual growth** or **unfolding**¹⁵. According to the deep ecologist, however, this unfolding is not complete. The **full unfolding** requires yet another development, which is by the identification as explained in II. This is the development of the metaphysical self into the **ecological self**¹⁶. It should be noted that SELF encompasses the self in any of the above senses, as well as the totality¹⁷. In fact this encompassing gives a characterization of SELF.

IV (Self-Realization $\uparrow \implies$ Joy of Life $\uparrow \wedge$ Meaning of Life $\uparrow$) A necessary and sufficient condition for self-realization is full unfolding. As any full unfolding is specific for any particular living being, “if one man gains spirituality, the whole world gains with him and, if one man fails, the whole world fails to that extent”¹⁸.

V (Identification is Beautiful) In Kantian terminology, development of the self into the ecological self is a beautiful act, as opposed to a moral act. This is ensured by love of oneself, which Næss takes as a primitive: “Surely you care for yourself without feeling any moral pressure to do it---provided you have not succumbed to a neurosis of some kind, developing self-destructive tendencies, or hating yourself.”¹⁹.

VI (Crisis of Joy) The environmental crisis is a threat against “the potential of joyful existence for all”.

Conclusion

Now let me elucidate what Næss considers the relation of man and Nature to be, and how this viewpoint underlies the concept of self-realization. Næss takes this relation to be a canonical one, and it is in fact implicit in the basic questions I cited in the beginning. Indeed, **Nature** is “the reality we live in”²⁰. Observe that taking (scientifically) nonliving things to be living in II makes sense only in this way. This way of defining Nature relates “being in the world” and “being in Nature”. In this regard there is also a converse of this definition: mankind belongs to the world as mobile parts²¹. At least two more direct evidence of how the connection of man and Nature justifies self-realization are available.

In III, the said connection justifies why the deep ecologist is not content with the traditional narrative of the development of the maturity of the self: The traditional narrative ignores

¹⁵[DevSes01, p. 67]

¹⁶[Næ87, p. 35] This sentence defines the ecological self implicitly. Indeed, “[t]he ecological self of a person is that with which this person identifies”, i.e. the ecological self is the instrument of identification, where identification is in the sense of II.

¹⁷[DevSes01, p. 76]

¹⁸[Næ87, p. 39]

¹⁹[Næ87, p. 39]

²⁰[Næ87, p. 41]

²¹[Næ87, p. 35] “[...] Earth, to whose surface we belong as mobile parts.”

Nature in two ways. First, it ignores that Nature is “our home, our immediate environment, where we belong as children”. Second, the development of the self into the metaphysical self falls short of identifying with other human beings²². Identifying with humanity need not mean identifying with (all) other beings: this can be obtained at the level of SELF.

Next, observe that in V Næss makes a deliberate choice of grammar in the phrase “love of ourself”. He could instead talk of “love of ourselves”, and clearly love of ourself is an extension of self-love corresponding to the development of the self into the ecological self. Thus it suffices to clarify the relation between self-love and self-realization. This relation is due to self-interest. For this Næss cites Erich Fromm:

[...] the interest of humans is to preserve their existence, which is the same as realizing their inherent potentialities.²³

According to Næss, “preserving one’s existence” is a matter of survival, hence he modifies this phrase into “persevering in one’s being”, which he takes to correspond to “acting out one’s own Nature”²⁴. The connection between man and Nature and how it underlies self-realization is thus clear.

²²[Næ87, p. 35]

²³[Næ87, p. 37]

²⁴[Næ87, p. 37]

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